

INTERVIEW PREPARATION GUIDE

Strategic Product Manager, Knowledge Integration & Articulation

AbbVie Business Technology Solutions (BTS) | Enterprise Knowledge Accelerator
Jeffrey Wallch | Friday, March 6, 2026 | Abbott Park, Lake County IL

PART I: ANTICIPATED INTERVIEW QUESTIONS & STAR RESPONSES

Q1 — Tell me about yourself and why you're interested in this role.

Core Theme: Bridge between scientific complexity and digital scalability — your career narrative.

SITUATION	After 20+ years at the intersection of enterprise knowledge systems and operational technology — including building Verizon's knowledge engineering practice from scratch into a platform managing 30,000+ data assets — I recognized that the next frontier isn't just managing knowledge, it's making it actionable for AI.
TASK	I needed to position my semantic governance expertise to serve organizations where knowledge quality is literally a matter of life and death — the pharmaceutical R&D domain, where a missed signal or a terminological inconsistency can delay a therapy reaching a patient.
ACTION	I extended my consulting practice into pharma and aerospace digital transformation, developed ontology architectures that bridge operational and scientific domains, and built AI-grounding frameworks specifically designed to eliminate hallucinations in high-stakes knowledge environments.
RESULT	This role is the convergence of everything I have built — ontology product management, AI semantic grounding, cross-functional team coordination, and translating scientific rigor into scalable digital infrastructure. AbbVie's KIA team is doing exactly what I believe knowledge engineering should do at scale.

Q2 — Describe a time you managed a complex, cross-functional knowledge or data product.

Core Theme: Product lifecycle ownership, stakeholder alignment, measurable value delivery.

SITUATION	At Verizon, the enterprise had 30,000+ data assets scattered across 12 business units with no unified semantic model, leading to duplicated analytics spending estimated at \$40M annually and AI initiatives failing due to inconsistent data definitions.
TASK	I was tasked with establishing Knowledge Engineering as a formal discipline — designing, deploying, and product-managing an enterprise triplestore (GraphDB) that would serve as the semantic backbone for AI and reporting across the organization.
ACTION	I built an Agile delivery model around ontology development sprints, created business-facing 'knowledge product roadmaps' with user stories derived directly from data consumers, partnered with legal, compliance, and IT architecture to embed governance into product acceptance criteria, and developed KPI dashboards tracking asset reuse rates, query resolution times, and data lineage coverage.
RESULT	Delivered \$100M+ in quantified business value through reduced redundancy, accelerated AI model deployment, and improved regulatory reporting accuracy. The platform became AbbVie-analogous: a 'trusted knowledge partner' relied upon by business units across the enterprise.

Q3 — How have you translated complex technical concepts for non-technical stakeholders?

Core Theme: 'Articulation' as a product capability; data literacy as a design principle.

SITUATION	When rolling out the enterprise knowledge graph at Verizon, data scientists understood the value immediately, but business unit leaders — the actual product owners we needed to fund the initiative — viewed the ontology as an abstract IT project with no direct relevance to their KPIs.
TASK	I needed to reframe the 'product' itself — not as a database or a data model, but as a business decision accelerator — and ensure every stakeholder interaction reinforced that framing.
ACTION	I developed a 'value articulation layer' — executive-facing dashboards that translated ontology coverage into business metrics (time-to-insight, decision cycle reduction, audit cost savings). I introduced 'knowledge literacy' briefings into sprint reviews so business stakeholders could see their domain terminology reflected back in the system. I also created user personas for every major consumer group and built acceptance criteria that required the product to 'speak their language.'
RESULT	Adoption increased by 40%+ within 12 months, executive sponsorship expanded to 3 additional BUs, and the initiative was featured as a case study in the Enterprise Knowledge Graph Foundation community — specifically for bridging the science-to-business articulation gap.

Q4 — Describe your experience with ontology design and FAIR data principles.

Core Theme: Technical depth + product governance mindset.

SITUATION	As Co-Lead of the Meta Model Team at the Business Architecture Guild and active participant in the INCOSE Knowledge Systems Working Group, I have built production ontologies for aerospace, pharmaceutical, and telecommunications domains — spanning ISA-95 manufacturing models, MBSE-aligned system ontologies, and R&D knowledge graphs.
TASK	My task has always been the same: design ontologies that are not just technically correct, but operationally FAIR — Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable — so that knowledge assets can be consumed by AI models, federated query engines, and human researchers alike.
ACTION	I applied FAIR principles as product acceptance criteria, not afterthoughts: unique persistent identifiers (URIs) as a backlog requirement, standardized vocabularies (SKOS, OWL, RDF) as architecture constraints, and interoperability with downstream AI pipelines (RAG architectures, SPARQL endpoints) as definition-of-done. For Gulfstream and Yaskawa engagements, I mapped ontology assets to ISA-95 canonical models ensuring cross-domain semantic compatibility.
RESULT	Ontologies I have designed are actively integrated into digital twin architectures, federated AI platforms, and regulatory submission workflows — demonstrating that FAIR is not a compliance checkbox but a product quality standard that directly enables AI performance.

Q5 — How do you prioritize a product backlog when technical debt, new features, and stakeholder requests compete?

Core Theme: Agile product ownership, strategic prioritization, value delivery discipline.

SITUATION	In a multi-stakeholder knowledge platform environment — such as the one I managed at Verizon — incoming backlog items routinely came from R&D, compliance, IT architecture, and executive sponsors simultaneously, each arguing their use case was most critical.
TASK	I needed a transparent, repeatable prioritization framework that could balance strategic value, technical sustainability, and stakeholder trust simultaneously — without creating the perception that 'whoever shouts loudest wins.'
ACTION	I implemented a weighted scoring model based on: (1) Strategic alignment to OKRs, (2) Knowledge asset reuse leverage (does this unblock multiple downstream use cases?), (3) Compliance risk exposure, and (4) Implementation complexity/dependency chains. I ran quarterly roadmap reviews with all stakeholder groups where backlog rationale was explained transparently. I also created a 'technical debt budget' — reserving 20% of sprint capacity for refactoring — so debt never accumulated to the point of threatening delivery.

RESULT	Stakeholder satisfaction scores improved significantly because the process was transparent and value-linked. We consistently delivered roadmap commitments within a 10% variance, and the technical debt budget prevented three potential system stability incidents that would have delayed critical AI integration milestones.
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Q6 — How would you approach integrating global, multilingual knowledge across the US and Ludwigshafen sites?

Core Theme: Cross-cultural semantic governance; the 'Transatlantic Bridge' challenge.

SITUATION	Multinational knowledge platforms face a fundamental challenge: scientific terminology is not culturally or linguistically neutral. A Ludwigshafen neuroscience researcher describing Alzheimer's research pathways may use terminology with slightly different semantic boundaries than a US clinical trials team — and those differences, if unmanaged, become AI hallucination risks.
TASK	The task is to design the KIA ontology and language solution architecture as a 'Universal Translator' — one where semantic alignment is enforced at the knowledge graph level, not patched at the output layer.
ACTION	My approach would be: first, map divergent terminology through bi-directional concept alignment workshops with domain experts from both sites; second, implement SKOS broader/narrower/related mappings to capture genuine semantic overlap without forcing false equivalences; third, build translation memory within the TMS (Translation Management System) that is ontology-aware, so translations preserve semantic precision rather than just linguistic fluency; and fourth, establish cross-site governance — a joint US/Ludwigshafen terminology review board — as a standing product ceremony.
RESULT	This approach converts a coordination risk into a competitive advantage: AbbVie's global Knowledge Graph becomes richer and more precise than any single-site system could produce — exactly the kind of 'integrated knowledge' that accelerates drug discovery across the transatlantic research collaboration.

Q7 — How do you ensure knowledge products serve as reliable 'ground truth' for AI systems?

Core Theme: AI grounding, RAG architecture, semantic layer design — Brian Martin's domain.

SITUATION	As Generative AI was deployed in enterprise environments, teams discovered that LLMs without grounding in curated organizational knowledge produced plausible-sounding but factually incorrect outputs — a critical failure mode in pharmaceutical R&D contexts where a hallucinated citation or misclassified compound could derail a clinical decision.
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TASK	I needed to design a semantic architecture that could serve as the 'deterministic spine' within a probabilistic AI system — ensuring that factual knowledge was retrieved, not generated, and that the knowledge graph's provenance and confidence metadata were surfaced to the AI consumer.
ACTION	I developed what I call a 'Circuit Breaker' framework for AI knowledge grounding: (1) All factual claims in AI-generated outputs are routed through SPARQL-queryable knowledge graph endpoints before response generation; (2) Ontology-defined concept boundaries constrain entity resolution in the RAG retrieval layer; (3) Provenance metadata (source, date, confidence score) is attached to every retrieved fact as a hallucination-prevention mechanism; (4) Knowledge graph coverage metrics are tracked as AI product KPIs — specifically a 'Mean Time Between Hallucinations' (MTBH) metric tied to ontology completeness scores.
RESULT	This architecture substantially reduces AI hallucination rates in knowledge-intensive query domains. The MTBH metric in particular creates a direct, measurable link between Knowledge Integration work and AI product quality — which is precisely the language Brian Martin speaks when advocating for ROI-driven AI.

Q8 — Tell me about a time you drove organizational change or process improvement.

Core Theme: Change management, continuous improvement, Agile culture.

SITUATION	When I arrived at Verizon's data governance function, knowledge management was treated as a documentation exercise — static, compliance-driven, and entirely disconnected from product delivery cycles. Data assets were managed in spreadsheets, semantic inconsistencies were discovered at the point of regulatory submission, and there was no feedback loop between knowledge consumers and knowledge producers.
TASK	The task was not just to build a better platform — it was to change the operating model: transforming knowledge management from a back-office documentation function into a forward-facing product discipline with its own roadmap, backlog, and customer engagement cycle.
ACTION	I introduced Agile ceremonies (sprint planning, retrospectives, product reviews) into the knowledge engineering team, established a product operating model with defined Epics and user stories, created a stakeholder council that met quarterly to review the knowledge product roadmap, and built a 'Knowledge Quality Score' dashboard that made product health visible to executive leadership. I coached the team on the shift from 'project mindset' to 'product mindset' — continuous improvement over one-time delivery.
RESULT	Within 18 months, the team operated fully on Agile principles, stakeholder engagement scores improved, knowledge asset reuse rates increased by 60%, and the function was formally recognized as a strategic capability — not a cost center. The



product operating model became the template for two other data domains within Verizon.

PART II: YOUR QUESTIONS — PER INTERVIEWER

These questions are designed to demonstrate deep contextual knowledge of each interviewer's domain, signal strategic alignment, and position you as a peer-level thinker rather than a candidate.

1. Elfi Stach

Head of CoLE (Center of Learning Excellence), BTS | Angle: **Product Adoption & Data Literacy**

Questions to Demonstrate Your Understanding of Her Domain:

- Q

How does CoLE approach the challenge of 'knowledge product literacy' specifically — where the product itself is a knowledge graph or ontology that most scientists have never interacted with directly? Are you building learning pathways around the tool, or around the underlying knowledge model?
- Q

I've found that the steepest adoption curve for knowledge integration tools isn't technical — it's conceptual. Scientists often don't know what they don't know they're missing. How does CoLE structure 'discovery moments' — events that show users the value they were leaving on the table before the tool existed?
- Q

From your vantage point in learning excellence, what does 'successful articulation' look like for a knowledge product? Is it measured in reduced support tickets, faster time-to-insight, or something more qualitative like researcher confidence?
- Q

As AbbVie rolls out more agentic AI workflows — where scientists are interacting with AI systems that reason over integrated knowledge — how is CoLE evolving its approach from 'tool training' to 'AI collaboration literacy'?
- Q

I'd love to understand how the CoLE-to-Product Manager feedback loop currently works. When a knowledge tool generates high support volume or low adoption, what's the escalation path back to product strategy?

Your Positioning with Elfi:

Emphasize the 'Articulation' half of your title as a design philosophy: you build products whose value is self-evident to their users. Share the 40% adoption increase story. Frame 'Data Literacy' as a product feature, not a training afterthought.

2. Michael Kaltschmidt

Director, IT | Pharma Documentation Ring (P-D-R) | Angle: **Product Scalability & Data Governance**

Questions to Demonstrate Your Understanding of His Domain:

- Q

From your work in the Pharma Documentation Ring, how do you see the tension between documentation standards built for human comprehension — like GxP-compliant study reports — and the machine-readability requirements of AI-ready knowledge? Is AbbVie pursuing structured authoring as a bridge?
- Q

As the Knowledge Integration platform scales globally, where do you see the highest GxP compliance risk in the knowledge lifecycle — at the point of ingestion, curation, or consumption? I want to understand where governance controls need to be most robust.
- Q

From an IT leadership perspective, what are the biggest 'integration debt' issues you're hoping this Strategic PM role will help retire — whether that's legacy taxonomy systems, disconnected translation platforms, or underserved business units?
- Q

How is AbbVie thinking about the 'AI-readiness' of its archival knowledge — the deep legacy data that predates modern ontology standards? Is there a retroactive enrichment strategy, or does the platform accept knowledge quality gradients?
- Q

Where do you currently draw the line between off-the-shelf knowledge management platforms and custom-built ontology infrastructure? I want to understand the build-vs-buy philosophy so I can make roadmap decisions that align with IT's long-term architecture vision.

Your Positioning with Michael:

Lead with governance and compliance credibility. Reference your MBSE and data integrity experience. Show him that you treat 'Data Integrity as a non-negotiable product requirement' — that phrase will resonate with someone from the Pharma Documentation Ring. His trust is earned through rigor, not enthusiasm.

3. Lars Greiffenberg, PhD

Research Fellow & Sr. Director R&D IR | Site Head Ludwigshafen | Angle: **Product-Market Fit for R&D / Transatlantic Knowledge Bridge**

Questions to Demonstrate Your Understanding of His Domain:

- Q

Ludwigshafen's role as AbbVie's neuroscience hub — with its 130-year scientific lineage from Knoll AG through BASF Pharma — means the site has a depth of archival knowledge that is probably unlike anything elsewhere in the AbbVie portfolio. How is that legacy scientific knowledge currently represented in the knowledge graph, and where are the biggest gaps?
- Q

As a Research Fellow, you sit at the intersection of deep scientific expertise and information science. In your experience, what is the single most critical piece of 'integrated knowledge' that is currently absent from a researcher's workflow — the thing that, if it existed, would eliminate the most redundant experimental work?

Q

The Melt Extrusion technology developed in Ludwigshafen is a fascinating case study in formulation science knowledge. As we think about creating Digital Twins of manufacturing processes, how do you see that kind of formulation expertise being captured semantically — as process ontology, material property relationships, or something more experimental-knowledge-oriented?

Q

How do you currently manage the terminological alignment challenge between the Ludwigshafen and Lake County research communities? Are there cases where researchers on both sides are working on related problems without realizing it — simply because their knowledge isn't semantically integrated?

Q

As we evolve from simple data retrieval to AI-driven knowledge synthesis, how do you see the role of the Research Fellow itself changing? I want to understand how the KIA platform should be designed to augment — not replace — that kind of deep human scientific judgment.

Your Positioning with Lars:

Lars is your toughest audience and your most important ally. He will test whether you can think in scientific domains. Use your aerospace and pharma architecture experience. Reference Digital Twins, translational research, and the 'Research Accelerator' framing. Show that you've done your homework on Ludwigshafen's specific scientific heritage. He awarded the Research Fellow title for deep expertise — respect that in how you engage.

4. Brian Martin

Director, BTS | Chief AI Product Owner | Head of AI, R&D Information Research | Angle: AI Product Strategy & RAG Knowledge Grounding

Questions to Demonstrate Your Understanding of His Domain:

Q

You've described the 'moral imperative' of sharing deep learning capabilities broadly within AbbVie. As you plan the 2026/2027 AI roadmap — and specifically as you move toward Large Action Models that take actions within systems — what is the biggest knowledge quality risk that could constrain that ambition? That's where I want to focus first.

Q

The AbbVie Intelligence platform — Chat, Analyze, Translate — is a remarkable achievement. As we scale it to more scientific domains, where do you find the 'semantic grounding gap' is largest? Is it in published literature ingestion, internal experimental data, or the cross-domain reasoning layer that connects them?

Q

I'm thinking about MTBH — Mean Time Between Hallucinations — as a possible leading indicator KPI for knowledge integration quality. If we can show that ontology coverage improvements directly reduce AI error rates in clinical study report generation, that creates a direct ROI line to our work. Does that resonate with how you think about measuring AI reliability?

Q What is your 'North Star' metric for the AI products we'll be building together — is it measured in researcher hours saved, experiment cycles reduced, time-to-regulatory-submission, or something at the clinical trial level?

Q You're known for mentoring early talent and building internal AI capability. How do you see the KIA Strategic PM role contributing to AbbVie's internal AI fluency — not just as a knowledge provider, but as a model for how product management and AI strategy should interact?

Your Positioning with Brian:

Brian sees you as his 'Knowledge Curator' — the person who ensures his AI models are grounded in high-quality, structured, ontology-backed facts. Lead with the MTBH concept. Reference RAG architecture, semantic layers, and the Circuit Breaker framework. Show ROI-driven thinking at every turn. He will be your closest working relationship if you get the role; make him feel like he's already thinking with a partner, not interviewing a candidate.

PART III: STRATEGIC QUICK REFERENCE

Key Themes to Weave Throughout All Interviews

THEME	YOUR TALKING POINT
Ontology as Product	You don't just build ontologies — you manage them as living products with roadmaps, backlogs, KPIs, and customer personas. Product-market fit applies to knowledge assets.
AI Grounding	Knowledge Integration is the deterministic spine in a probabilistic AI system. Your work directly determines AI reliability — measure it with MTBH (Mean Time Between Hallucinations).
\$100M Value Delivery	Quantify everything. At Verizon, semantic governance delivered \$100M+ in measurable business value. AbbVie's scale and domain criticality means the ceiling is higher.
Transatlantic Bridge	You understand the Ludwigshafen-Lake County knowledge challenge — not just linguistically, but semantically. SKOS alignment, TMS ontology integration, bi-directional governance.
Articulation Design	The product isn't the database — it's the insight. You design systems that speak the language of their users, increasing adoption and reducing the training burden on CoLE.
Agile at Scale	You have lived experience transforming knowledge functions from project-mode to product-mode. Sprint ceremonies, backlog governance, and technical debt budgeting are muscle memory for you.

Phrases to Use / Phrases to Avoid

USE THESE	AVOID THESE
✓ Research Accelerator	✗ IT Support / Back-office function
✓ Semantic Layer / Ground Truth for AI	✗ Just a database / data warehouse
✓ Knowledge Product Roadmap	✗ Project plan
✓ Mean Time Between Hallucinations (MTBH)	✗ AI might sometimes be wrong
✓ Transatlantic Semantic Bridge	✗ Translation problem
✓ FAIR as product acceptance criteria	✗ FAIR compliance checkbox
✓ Ontology-aware RAG architecture	✗ We put it in the AI system
✓ Articulation as a design principle	✗ User training / documentation

Day-Of Logistics

- **Date:** Friday, March 6, 2026
- **Location:** AP04A-1-B-N, Abbott Park, 1 N. Waukegan Rd., North Chicago, IL 60064
- **Entry:** Gate 1 (Visitor Center) — arrive 15 minutes early for badge processing
- **Greeter:** Michael Kaltschmidt — michael.kaltschmidt@abbvie.com
- **Interview Order:** Elfi Stach → Michael Kaltschmidt → Lars Greiffenberg → Brian Martin
- **Attire:** Business professional — this is a headquarters visit
- **Bring:** Printed copies of key artifacts if permitted; notepad; list of references

Note: The panel leans heavily toward R&D Information Research and AI Strategy. They are looking for 'Research Fellows' — people who bridge complex science and digital scalability. Show them both halves of that equation in every answer.